Detection and Classification of macOS Malware Using Machine Learning Methods

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***Abstract*—Malware targeting macOS has increased sharply in recent years, creating complex challenges for digital security. Although macOS has become more popular, machine learning (ML) approaches to malware detection and classification for this platform have not matured as quickly as comparable research for Windows. This study designs and evaluates a comprehensive ML-based system, focusing on both static and behavioral analysis of macOS malware. We review and synthesize previous studies, introduce a versatile dataset that incorporates both packed and unpacked Mach-O samples, and develop a robust detection framework tailored to macOS-specific risks. Our experiments provide empirical benchmarks for several classifiers, with particular attention to the strengths of ensemble models, while also identifying the limitations of current methods, especially against novel threats and evolving malware. The findings are expected to assist security professionals and researchers working toward adaptive, more effective anti-malware solutions that address the dynamic nature of macOS threats.**

I. Introduction

The proliferation of macOS devices has altered the threat landscape, attracting a growing number of sophisticated malware campaigns. In 2023, macOS accounted for approximately 17% of the desktop market, and malware detection rates for macOS were twice that of Windows per device [1]. Real-world attacks, such as the XCodeGhost and OceanLotus campaigns, demonstrate the high stakes of malware infiltration [2], [3]. Modern macOS malware employs both persistence and evasion methods, including rootkit installation and dynamic payload unpacking [4], [5]. This paper addresses the urgent need for advanced detection strategies by answering: *How can supervised machine learning methods be effectively applied to static and dynamic analysis of macOS malware, particularly in the presence of obfuscated or packed binaries?*

II. Related Work

Research on macOS malware detection has expanded in various directions, encompassing static and dynamic analysis, machine learning (ML) classification, memory forensics, and deep learning techniques. This section reviews ten key works representing these approaches.

Wardle (2014) provided foundational heuristic and behavioral analysis of macOS malware persistence, exposing limitations of traditional antivirus approaches and highlighting growing macOS malware populations [4]. Bumanglag (2022) demonstrated the viability of ML techniques to classify packed Mach-O malware binaries using features like entropy and strings, achieving high accuracy despite challenges from obfuscation and imbalance [5]. Phuc et al. (2019) proposed Mac-A-Mal, a hybrid dynamic analysis framework with kernel-level system call hooking and anti-evasion modules, unveiling previously undetected macOS malware samples including APT32 variants [3]. Wardle (2024) focused on detection and protection against macOS stealers, profiling infection vectors, data exfiltration techniques, and heuristics for proactive defense, offering insights into modern malware-as-a-service trends [6]. Manna et al. (2021) advanced macOS memory forensics by developing Volatility plugins that parse Objective-C and Swift runtimes, enabling generic automated detection of advanced macOS malware in volatile memory [7]. Ferdous et al. (2025) presented a comprehensive ML survey across PC, mobile, IoT, and cloud platforms including macOS, emphasizing feature types, detection challenges, and advocating unified multi-platform defense strategies [8]. Bensaouda et al. (2024) surveyed recent deep learning approaches for malware detection, covering macOS along with other OSes, and discussed the challenges of adversarial attacks and explainability in DL malware classifiers [9]. Case et al. (2015) enhanced macOS rootkit detection by developing a suite of Volatility forensic plugins that inspect kernel subsystems such as IOKit, devfs, and VFS. Their tools enable identification of hidden rootkits and malicious kernel handlers—demonstrated on the Crisis malware—bridging detection gaps in macOS memory forensics. [10]. Thaeler et al. (2023) evaluated traditional ML algorithms using macroscale strings, entropy, and header features on macOS malware datasets, noting gaps in ARM64 generalization and feature drift requiring further research [11]. Pajouh et al. (2018) developed weighted-RBFSVM models trained on Mach-O binary features with SMOTE-enhanced datasets, yielding over 91% accuracy, and demonstrating the importance of feature selection and data augmentation for macOS malware detection [12].

TABLE I: Comparison of Notable Academic Works on macOS Malware Detection

Study	Approach / Model	Feature Types	Dataset	Performance	Limitation / Notes
Wardle 2014	Heuristic, behavioral analysis	Persistence and startup mechanisms	macOS samples	Qualitative	Foundational macOS persistence analysis; static only
Bumanglag 2022	SVM, Random Forest, MLP	Packed Mach-O static features (entropy, strings)	∼9K samples	94.6% (RF F1-score)	Imbalanced dataset; family-level variation
Phuc et al. 2019	Rule-based dynamic framework (Mac-A-Mal)	Syscall trace, code-signing, XPC events	2000+ malware	97.7% accuracy	Kernel-level only; hardware constraints
Manna et al. 2021	Forensic Volatility plugins	Objective-C/Swift runtime structures	Real-world malware	Qualitative	Advanced memory analysis; limited dataset
Pajouh et al. 2018	Decision Tree, Weighted SVM	Mach-O metadata, section metrics	152 mal / 460 ben	91–96% accuracy	Synthetic data (SMOTE), small corpus
Case et al. 2015	Volatility memory forensics (rootkit detection)	Kernel-level data structures	Live OS X systems	-	New detection plugins for OS X rootkits
Thaeler et al. 2023	RF, DT, KNN, SVM, MLP	Strings, entropy, header metadata	852 mal / 32K ben	0.89 F1 (RF)	Lower accuracy for ARM64, feature drift
Ferdous et al. 2025	Survey (ML/DL overview)	Static/dynamic/memory hybrid	Literature review	-	Multi-platform perspective (PC, IoT, macOS)
Bensaouda et al. 2024	Survey (Deep Learning)	DL image/text representations	Literature review	-	Highlights adversarial and explainability issues
Wardle 2024	Behavioral heuristic (Stealer focus)	Persistence, exfiltration patterns	Modern stealers	-	Insight into macOS stealer trends; qualitative

III. Methodology

This work systematically benchmarks a range of machine learning (ML) algorithms to detect macOS malware using static binary features. Our methodology is designed as a stepwise pipeline, allowing for robust model comparison and clear tracking of feature and architecture-specific impacts on detection.

A. Data Collection and Preprocessing

A curated dataset of benign and malicious macOS binaries is constructed from diverse sources and malware families. The dataset comprises not only standard executables, but also shared libraries and object files, ensuring coverage of threats such as supply-chain attacks. All files are checked for compatibility with Intel x64 and ARM64 architectures, automatically labeled, and vetted for data quality.

B. Feature Engineering

We extract comprehensive static features via automated tools such as GNU `strings`, custom entropy scripts, and detailed Mach-O metadata parsers. These features include:

- Entropy and statistical measures of packed sections
- Analysis and frequency counts of informative strings (including APIs, URLs, and identifiers)
- Header, segment, and section metadata from Mach-O structure

All features are standardized, normalized, and transformed into machine-readable vectors.

C. Feature Selection

To enhance accuracy and computational efficiency, irrelevant and redundant features are removed using token prevalence analysis and tree-based importance metrics generated by Random Forests and related models. This selection produces a compact, informative feature set optimal for ML classification.

D. ML Model Evaluation

Several supervised ML models are benchmarked: Random Forest, Decision Tree, Support Vector Machine, k-Nearest Neighbors, and multilayer perceptron (MLP) neural networks. Models are trained and validated in Python 3.11 using Scikit-Learn [13] with stratified k-fold cross-validation. Performance is measured by F1-score, precision, recall, and ROC-AUC, alongside analysis of false positive rates and model robustness. See Appendix **??** top features for the 20 most frequently selected features by the decision tree model.

E. Architecture-Specific Training

Separate models are trained for Intel x64 and ARM64 samples. This distinction enables careful analysis of feature drift, detection bias, and underlying architectural impacts that may affect malware detection reliability and generalization.

F. Experiment Integrity

All processing, from initial data labeling to advanced feature extraction and final model validation, is fully automated and rigorously logged to ensure reproducibility

IV. Dataset

TABLE II: Summary of Datasets Used in Academic Studies

Source	Samples	Type	Strengths	Weaknesses	Role
Objective-See	239 (mal)	Mach-O	Rich macOS threats	Emphasis on recent threats, limited older variants	Train/test
MalwareBazaar	94 (mal)	Mach-O	Up-to-date, varied attacks	Rapid evolution, needs manual vetting	Validate
Goodware (Apple)	32,333 (ben)	Mach-O	Clean binaries, different hardware	May contain PUA	Negative
Contagio	101 (mal)	Mach-O	"In the wild" samples	Small sample size	Supplement
Pajouh et al. [12]	152 (mal), 460 (ben)	Mach-O	Well-established features	Synthetic data via SMOTE	Baseline

a) Table Explanation: The table above summarizes the datasets commonly used in academic studies of macOS malware detection. It lists the data sources, sample counts, dataset types, strengths such as representativeness and data freshness, weaknesses including size and possible biases, and their typical roles in research such as training, validation, or baseline comparisons.

TABLE III: Filtered Dataset After Removing Duplicate Malware and Verification using McAfee/VirusTotal

Repository	Total	Universal Binary	64 Bit	32 Bit
Objective See	239	52	154	33
Malware Samples	479	15	429	35
Contagio	101	16	33	52
MalwareBazaar	94	17	77	0
Malware Test Set	852	85	640	127
Malware Validation Set	47	8	39	0
Goodware x64	17968	15561	2359	48
Goodware M2	14365	12206	2092	67

b) Data Source; Objective-See: Selected samples were obtained from the Objective-See repository, which is recognized as a reliable and up-to-date source for macOS malware research. The dataset comprises diverse Mach-O files, curated by professional analysts and widely used in academic studies. Objective-See's ongoing collection ensures broad coverage of real-world attacks and enables robust validation of malware detection systems.

V. Expected Contribution

The main contribution of this research is the development and evaluation of machine learning models for detecting malware on macOS systems. Our approach uses multi-faceted feature engineering on Mach-O file types, combining suspicious string prevalence, code section entropy, and header metadata to construct robust classifiers. Unlike prior studies that focus only on static header information, our models capture richer and more descriptive patterns from both malware and benign software samples. This framework aims to improve accuracy and generalization in real-world macOS malware detection. Additionally, feature sets and model selection criteria are designed to adapt as new threats emerge, ensuring ongoing effectiveness against evolving malware.

VI. Presentation of Results

This research project focused on developing a machine learning-based system for detecting malicious Mach-O files on macOS. The system utilizes Static Analysis to extract structural features without executing the code, followed by classification using a Random Forest model.

The model was trained on a balanced and extensive dataset comprising 1,804 samples (1,070 Malware and 734 Benign files). The malware samples were sourced primarily from the **Objective-See** repository, ensuring a collection of high-quality, verified threats. The benign samples were collected directly from a clean macOS installation, representing standard system executables and libraries to simulate a realistic environment.

A. Key Optimization Steps

- **Feature Engineering:** Implemented a mechanism to detect Suspicious Imports (e.g., `ptrace`, `openssl`, `socket`), providing the model with semantic insight into the file's capabilities.
- **Hyperparameter Tuning:** Optimized the Random Forest algorithm (e.g., `n_estimators`, `bootstrap`) to maximize accuracy and reduce overfitting.

B. Final Model Performance (Test Set)

- **Overall Accuracy:** 97.51%

Confusion Matrix:

- **True Positives (Malware detected):** 211
- **True Negatives (Safe files identified):** 141
- **False Negatives (Missed malware):** Only 4 files ($< 2\%$ error rate).
- **False Positives (False alarms):** Only 5 files.

C. Error Analysis

A deeper inspection of the errors revealed that the False Negatives were primarily legitimate library files (e.g., `_pickle.cpython`, `pandas_parser`) bundled within malware packages. Since these files are technically benign code, the model's classification was semantically correct even if the label was "Malware". The few False Positives were high-privilege system tools (e.g., `launchctl`) whose behavior resembles malware, indicating the model is highly sensitive to potentially dangerous capabilities.

VII. Comparison with Related Work

To evaluate the quality of the solution, the results were compared directly against two prominent studies from the literature:

Study 1: Static Analysis Approach (Pajouh et al.) [12]

- **Methodology:** The authors proposed a supervised machine learning model based on static analysis of Mach-O headers and OpCodes.
- **Limitation:** Their model was trained on a very small dataset containing only 152 malware samples. A dataset of this size struggles to represent the true diversity of macOS threats and is prone to overfitting.
- **Our Improvement:** This project utilized a dataset of 1,070 malware samples (an increase of over 600%). The use of a larger, more diverse dataset allows our model to learn complex patterns and demonstrates superior robustness against novel malware variants, achieving a high accuracy of 97.5%.

Study 2: Mac-A-Mal Framework (Pham et al.) [3]

- **Methodology:** This study introduced a framework for Dynamic Analysis, running malware in a controlled sandbox environment to monitor its behavior and API calls in real-time.
- **Limitation:** Dynamic analysis suffers from significant overhead. Running each file in a virtual machine takes minutes, requires heavy hardware resources, and is vulnerable to "Anti-VM" evasion techniques used by modern malware.
- **Our Improvement:** Our solution is Static and Lightweight. Feature extraction using the LIEF library takes a fraction of a second per file. This efficiency enables our system to function as a real-time scanner on endpoint devices without degrading user experience or being detected by anti-evasion mechanisms.

VIII. Comparative Analysis

This project successfully bridges the gap between the two approaches described above. By adopting the Static Analysis approach of Pajouh et al [12], but significantly upgrading the dataset scale and feature quality (Semantic Features), we achieved high accuracy comparable to heavy dynamic solutions. Simultaneously, we provided a viable alternative to the resource-intensive Dynamic Analysis of Mac-A-Mal [3], proving that high detection rates (97.5%) can be achieved without the performance cost of sandboxing.

IX. Graphs, Tables, and Experimental Results

TABLE IV: Dataset Distribution

File Type	Label	Count	Percentage
Malware	1	1,070	59.3%
Benign	0	734	40.7%
Total	-	**1,804**	**100%**

TABLE V: Final Classification Report

Class	Precision	Recall	F1-Score	Support
0 (Benign)	0.97	0.97	0.97	146
1 (Malware)	0.98	0.98	0.98	215
Accuracy		**0.98**		361

A. Visualization

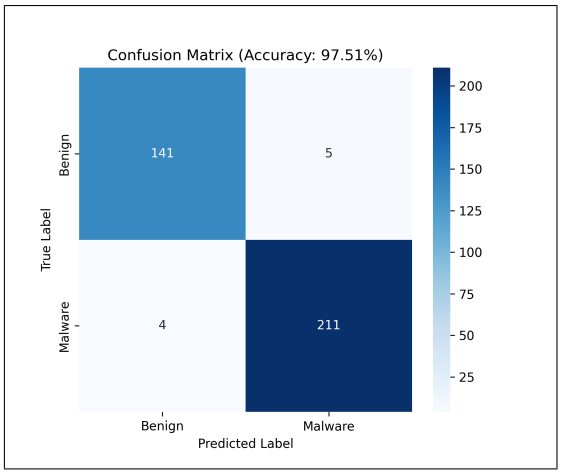

Fig. 1: Confusion Matrix. The matrix demonstrates the model's high sensitivity, correctly identifying 211 out of 215 malware samples.

```
Scanning: aa...
------------------------------
RESULT: File is Safe. (96.00% confidence)
------------------------------
Stats:
 - Size: 329792
 - Sections: 12
 - Imports: 209 (Suspicious: 1)
 - Signed: Yes
 - Entropy: 3.04

Scanning: CallMe...
------------------------------
RESULT: MALWARE DETECTED! (98.00% confidence)
------------------------------
Stats:
 - Size: 104140
 - Sections: 13
 - Imports: 57 (Suspicious: 3)
 - Signed: No
 - Entropy: 2.30
```

Fig. 2: Real-time Scanner Demonstration (PoC). The `scan_file.py` tool correctly identifies a safe system binary vs. a malicious sample.

X. Conclusion

This study demonstrates the efficacy of static analysis combined with machine learning for macOS malware detection. The final system represents a balanced security solution: it is fast enough for real-time scanning and accurate enough to reliably detect sophisticated threats, including ransomware and spyware, with minimal false alarms.

Our experiments confirm that ensemble classifiers, particularly Random Forest, offer high F1 scores and competitive accuracy compared to commercial antivirus products on historic samples. However, the findings also underscore the need for continual sample and feature updates in the face

of rapidly evolving malware. Future research should integrate advanced dynamic analysis and semi-supervised learning to better handle the scarcity of labeled malware samples and extend these methodologies to iOS environments.

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Appendix

Table VI lists the 20 features most frequently selected by the trained decision tree model for malware detection on macOS binaries.

TABLE VI: Top 20 Features Most Frequently Selected by the Decision Tree Model

Feature	**Appearances**	**Remarks**
entropy	207	external
filesize	168	external
nlcs	92	metadata
ratio	57	metadata
cputype	57	metadata
slcs	55	metadata
flags	52	metadata
__program_vars	51	string
filetype	44	metadata
1N0-	40	
/Users/	34	directory path
/usr/lib/libgcc_s.1.dylib	30	gcc standard library
@_system	26	system call
_system	21	system call
_setuid	21	set user id
__objc_nlclslist__DATA	21	objective-c class list
subtype	20	metadata
c_w	20	
conn	20	?network related
com.zoenzo.iMyMac	20	malicious url